MY MENTAL GAME

7 skills. 1 page each.

NAME

Consistent | Persistent | Resilient | Relentless | Respectful

KEEP WRESTLING - EVERYDAY IS A NEW MATCH!

Goes with Steve Knight's book *Winning State Wrestling*. Not written or endorsed by Steve Knight or his publisher.

How it works

One skill per page. Every page has the same 3 steps. About 5 minutes each.

1 READ
3 short lines.

2 DO
Circle, color, draw, or connect.

3 TRY IT
Use it at practice. Check the box.

1. **Train Your Brain**
   Mental toughness is a skill. You can train it.
2. **Nerves Are Fuel**
   Nerves mean your body is getting ready.
3. **Box Breathing**
   Your breath is your brake pedal.
4. **Big Dog Talk**
   Talk to yourself like a great coach.
5. **Proof Jar**
   Believe it because you did it.
6. **Picture the Match**
   Picture the hard part, not just the win.
7. **Flip the Switch**
   Practice mode off. Match mode on.
★ **My Card**
   Your best tools on one card.

CPR3: OUR 5 PILLARS

Consistent	Do your good habits every day.
Persistent	Keep working when it doesn't work the first time.
Resilient	Bounce back after a mistake.
Relentless	Keep going. Don't quit.
Respectful	Treat teammates, coaches, refs, and opponents well.

1 Train Your Brain

Mental toughness is a skill. You can train it.

1% Better

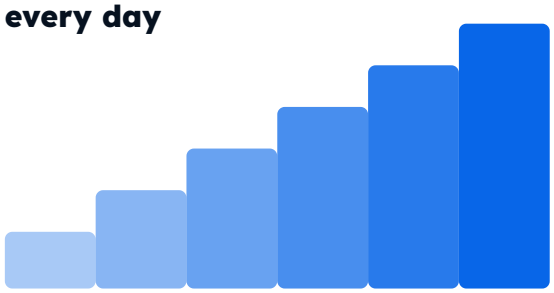
1 READ

You train your moves every day.

You can train your thinking the same way.

Small steps every day add up. That is 1% Better.

1% better every day



COACH KNIGHT SAYS Coach Knight says being tough is not the same as feeling confident. Tough means you keep going, even when you have doubts. [K5]

SCIENCE SAYS Athletes who practice mental skills get better at their sport. [S12]

2 DO

Circle ONE thing to get 1% better at this week.

Good stance | Hand fighting | Taking shots | Getting up from bottom

Staying calm after a mistake | Wrestling the whole 6 minutes

My own: _____

3 TRY IT AT PRACTICE

At practice, do your one thing on purpose. Do it again tomorrow.

☐ I did it at practice ☐ I used it in a match

2 Nerves Are Fuel

Nerves mean your body is getting ready.

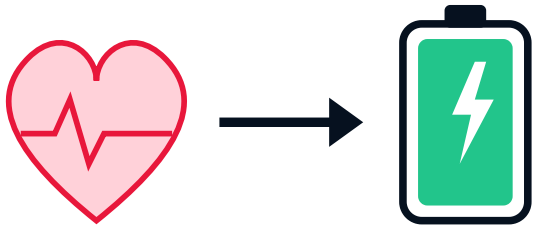
Be You

1 READ

Before a match, your heart may race.

That is not a bad sign. It is your body getting ready to wrestle.

Even the best wrestlers get nervous.



nerves fuel

COACH KNIGHT SAYS Coach Knight's first tip is Love Nerves. Use your nerves. Don't run from them. [K3]

SCIENCE SAYS People who said "I'm excited" did better than people who told themselves "I'm calm." [S4]

2 DO

Circle what YOUR body does when you're nervous.

Heart races | Sweaty hands | Stomach flips | Shaky legs

Can't sit still | Feel tired or yawn | My own: _____

Circle your FUEL WORDS. Say them before a match.

I'm excited. | My body is ready. | Let's go. | I've got this.

My own: _____

3 TRY IT AT PRACTICE

Before your next live go, say your fuel words.

☐ I did it at practice ☐ I used it in a match

3 Box Breathing

Your breath is your brake pedal.

Core Four

1 READ

Slow breathing helps your body calm down.

Breathe in for 4. Hold for 4. Breathe out for 4. Hold for 4.

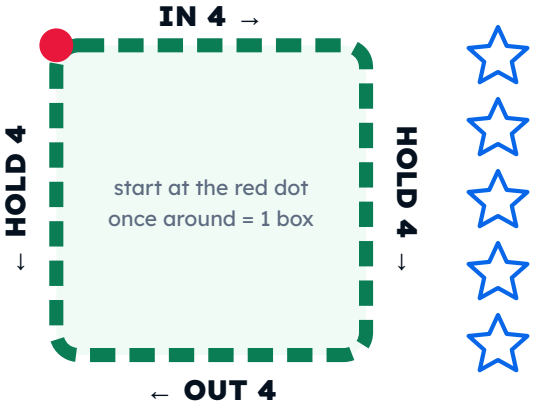
That is one box. Coach Arnie calls it 4-4-4-4.

COACH KNIGHT SAYS Coach Knight teaches Gut Breathing. Breathe low into your belly. [K6]

SCIENCE SAYS A few minutes of slow breathing helped people feel calmer and in a better mood. [S7]

2 DO

Trace the box with your finger as you breathe. Color a star each time you finish a box.



Circle when you will use it.

Before my match | Out of bounds | Between periods | Before bed | Before a test

Feel dizzy? Stop and breathe normally.

3 TRY IT AT PRACTICE

Do 3 boxes before your first live go.

☐ I did it at practice ☐ I used it in a match

4 Big Dog Talk

Talk to yourself like a great coach.

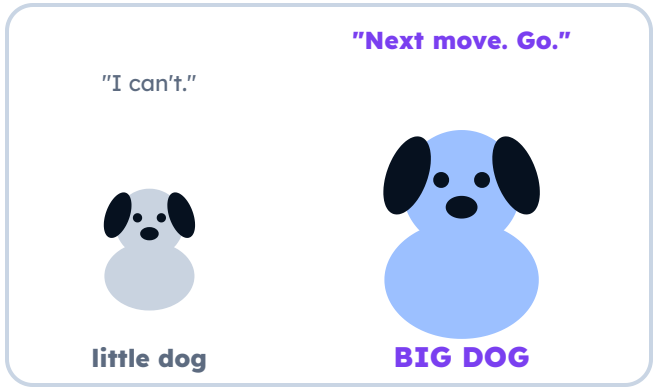
Persistent

1 READ

Everyone has a voice in their head.

The little dog voice says scared or mean things.

The Big Dog voice tells you what to do next.



COACH KNIGHT SAYS The Winning State books say every wrestler has a little dog and a BIG Dog inside. [K7]

SCIENCE SAYS Short words about what to do next help athletes do better. [S1]

2 DO

Draw a line from each little dog line to the Big Dog answer.

LITTLE DOG	BIG DOG
"I'm too tired."	"Next move. Go."
"I messed up."	"Yes I can. I've trained for this."
"I can't beat her."	"One more push."

My Big Dog words:

3 TRY IT AT PRACTICE

After a missed move, say your Big Dog words. Then go again right away.

☐ I did it at practice ☐ I used it in a match

5 Proof Jar

Believe it because you did it.

Consistent

1 READ

Proof is something tough you really did.

Remembering your proof helps you believe in yourself.

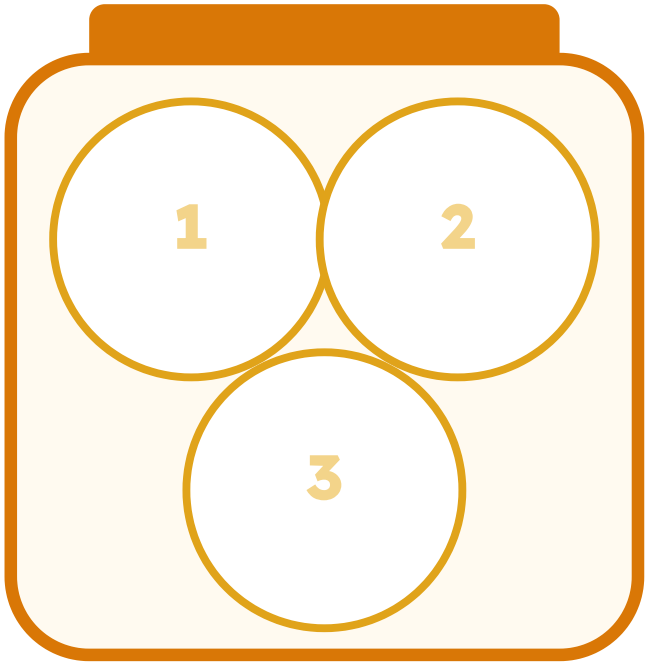
Proof can come from a loss too. Tough is how you act.

COACH KNIGHT SAYS Coach Knight calls this your BIG-DOG highlight reel. You did it before. You can do it again. [K6]

SCIENCE SAYS Remembering what you really did is one of the best ways to build belief. [S8]

2 DO

Write or draw 3 times you were tough. One coin each.



3 TRY IT AT PRACTICE

Before you leave practice, find one new proof. Tell a teammate.

☐ I did it at practice ☐ I used it in a match

6 Picture the Match

Picture the hard part, not just the win.

Relentless

1 READ

You can play your match in your head before you wrestle.

Don't just picture winning.

Picture the hard part, and what you will do.

COACH KNIGHT SAYS Coach Knight calls this Go-Time. Picturing only a win does not stop worry. A plan does. [K6]

SCIENCE SAYS Athletes who practice moves in their minds get better at them. [S12]

2 DO

Draw or write a few words in each box.

1 START

I see the mat.

2 GO

My first move.

3 PROBLEM

She stops it.

4 ANSWER

What I do next.

If she blocks my move, I will

3 TRY IT AT PRACTICE

Close your eyes. Play your match one time. Then drill it.

☐ I did it at practice ☐ I used it in a match

7 Flip the Switch

Practice mode off. Match mode on.

Resilient

1 READ

Before a match, do the same steps every time.

Then flip your switch to match mode.

If she scores, reset fast: Notice. Breathe. Big Dog. First Job.



Same steps. Every match.

COACH KNIGHT SAYS Coach Knight teaches a Competition Process. Tough wrestlers reset right away after a mistake. [K6 K8]

SCIENCE SAYS Athletes who do the same steps before they compete do better. [S14]

2 DO

Circle your SWITCH-ON move.

Slap my legs | Clap twice | One big breath | Fix my headgear

Bounce on my toes | My own: _____

Circle your FIRST JOB when the whistle blows.

Good stance | Win hand fight | Move my feet | Shoot first

My own: _____

If she scores, color each reset step as you do it:

1 Notice | **2 Breathe** | **3 Big Dog** | **4 First Job**

3 TRY IT AT PRACTICE

Start a live go down 0-2. Do your reset. Get right back to your plan.

☐ I did it at practice ☐ I used it in a match

My Card

Copy your circled answers from Skills 2, 4, and 7. Cut it out. Keep it in your bag.

MY CARD

FUEL WORDS _____

SWITCH ON _____

FIRST JOB _____

BIG DOG _____

RESET Notice → Breathe → Big Dog → First Job

MY CARD

FUEL WORDS _____

SWITCH ON _____

FIRST JOB _____

BIG DOG _____

RESET Notice → Breathe → Big Dog → First Job

GIVE A TEAMMATE SOME PROOF (THAT'S RESPECTFUL)

Write what you saw her do. Be specific.

PROOF FOR YOU

To: _____

I saw you...

_____

_____

That was _____ (Pillar)

PROOF FOR YOU

To: _____

I saw you...

_____

_____

That was _____ (Pillar)

PROOF FOR YOU

To: _____

I saw you...

_____

_____

That was _____ (Pillar)

Fuel + Rest

Fill in one bubble each time. 15 seconds a day. Copy this page each week.

Each day	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Water goal 4 bottles	○○○○	○○○○	○○○○	○○○○	○○○○	○○○○	○○○○
Fruit goal 2	○○	○○	○○	○○	○○	○○	○○
Veggies goal 2	○○	○○	○○	○○	○○	○○	○○
Breakfast	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sleep goal 8 to 10 hours	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Ready to train	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5

Never miss twice. Missed a day? That's okay. Just don't miss two in a row.

This is about fuel and rest, not weight. Wrestlers need to eat enough. Teens need 8 to 10 hours of sleep. [S19]

FOR COACHES

Running it in 5 minutes a skill

EACH SKILL

1. **Read it together.** Read the 3 lines out loud. Ask: "Has this happened to you?"
2. **Do it.** Give 2 to 3 minutes. Circling is enough. Don't grade it.
3. **Try it.** Put the Try It into a drill you already run that day.
4. **Next practice:** ask one quiz question out loud. Remembering is what makes it stick.

PACE

One skill a week. Skills 2, 3, and 7 matter most before tournaments. Use My Card on meet day, and don't teach anything new at mat-side.

PRAISE THAT HELPS

Say what you saw, then the Pillar: "You got scored on and went right back to attacking. That's Resilient."

KEEP IT SAFE

- This is sports skills, not therapy.
- Athletes never have to share what they wrote.
- Being tough never means hiding pain or an injury, especially a head injury.
- Fuel + Rest tracks eating *enough* and sleep. Never praise skipping meals or water to make weight.
- Breathing: stop if dizzy. No breath-holding contests.
- If something an athlete shares worries you, follow school reporting steps.

THE APP

The website has the same 7 skills with tap answers, a "Read it to me" button, a breathing timer, and Fuel + Rest. Athletes sign in with a school account or an email you invite. Coaches can see what athletes enter; teammates can't.

COACH KNIGHT SAYS **About the book.** Verified from the publisher: *Winning State Wrestling*, 4th ed., 164 pages, 7 chapters [K1]. The Coach Knight ideas here (Love Nerves, Gut Breathing, little dog and BIG Dog, Go-Time, the highlight reel, the Competition Process, the instant reset) come from his publisher's own materials [K3-K8]. The chapter titles aren't published, so this packet doesn't say which chapter covers what. Every activity here was made for Merrill and is not from the book. For more depth, use the full YOU University workbook.

FOR COACHES

Sources

COACH KNIGHT + PUBLISHER (PARAPHRASED, CHECKED NOV. 2026)

- **[K1]** WINNING STATE Wrestling product page, winningstate.com: 4th ed., 164 pp., 7 chapters, Let's Win! International, ISBN 979-8-9882909-4-0. Chapter titles are not published there.
- **[K3]** Knight, S. 'Mental Toughness for Young Athletes: Tactics to Win Under Pressure (Part 1/7).' winningstate.com. Tactic #1: Love Nerves.
- **[K5]** Knight, S. 'Are Confidence and Mental Toughness the Same?' winningstate.com.
- **[K6]** WINNING STATE Masterclass page, winningstate.com/masterclass-mental-toughness: Gut Breathing, BIG-DOG self-talk, Go-Time Visualization, BIG-DOG highlight reel, Competition Process.
- **[K7]** Winning State series back-cover text (Winning State Baseball, 2004): a little dog and a BIG Dog inside every competitor.
- **[K8]** winningstate.com home page: mentally tough athletes instantly reset after mistakes.

RESEARCH

- **[S1]** Hatzigeorgiadis, A., et al. (2011). Self-talk and sports performance: A meta-analysis. Perspectives on Psychological Science, 6(4), 348-356.
- **[S4]** Brooks, A. W. (2014). Get excited: Reappraising pre-performance anxiety as excitement. Journal of Experimental Psychology: General, 143(3), 1144-1158.
- **[S7]** Balban, M. Y., et al. (2023). Brief structured respiration practices enhance mood and reduce physiological arousal. Cell Reports Medicine, 4(1), 100895.
- **[S8]** Bandura, A. (1997). Self-efficacy: The exercise of control. W. H. Freeman.
- **[S12]** Frank, C., Kluever, J., & Simonsmeier, B. A. (2023). Imagery training in children and adolescents: A meta-analysis. International Review of Sport and Exercise Psychology.
- **[S14]** Rupprecht, A. G. O., Tran, U. S., & Gropel, P. (2021). The effectiveness of pre-performance routines in sports: A meta-analysis. International Review of Sport and Exercise Psychology, 17(1), 39-64.
- **[S19]** Paruthi, S., et al. (2016). Recommended amount of sleep for pediatric populations. Journal of Clinical Sleep Medicine, 12(6), 785-786 (teens 13-18: 8 to 10 hours).

Research shows average results, not a promise for any one athlete. That's why each skill gets tried at practice and kept only if it works.